bilingual composite province with the two parts CP and Berar being unequal in area, population, and prosperity. Vallabhbhai was pleased with Deshmukh's work, and as we shall see later, when he met him again in 1945, reminded him of this happy conclusion and asked if he could do anything for him (Deshmukh).[2]

In January 1939, Sir Girija Shankar Bajpai, Secretary to the Government of India in the Department of Education, Health and Lands asked Deshmukh if he was interested in joining him as Joint Secretary. Since the Finance Ministry had shown an interest in him earlier, Deshmukh asked for an informal clarification on this point and was told that the Sir Jeremy Raisman, who had succeeded Grigg as the Finance Member, anticipated no difficulty in arranging for Deshmukh's transfer to the Finance Ministry if required. With this assurance, Deshmukh left CP and Berar in May 1939 to join the Department of Education, Health and Lands.

Deshmukh joined his new assignment at Simla, the summer headquarters of the Government of India, but it was destined to be a very brief affair. Towards the end of June 1939, Raisman told Deshmukh that he, in consultation with Taylor, had decided to send him to the RBI as government Director. It was also decided that towards the end of the year, he would take over as Secretary of the Central Board from P.S. Beale who would be returning to England. Taylor was expected in Simla in the first week of July and Deshmukh was to accompany him, first to Calcutta, and then to Bombay. As a preliminary step, Deshmukh was transferred to the Finance Department as officer on special duty, an office he held over the weekend prior to his departure for Calcutta. Deshmukh may or may not have realized it, but a whole new world was opening up for him, one which would change forever the course of his career, and result in high achievement and much kudos.

'A Metamorphosis, Rich and Strange'

Deshmukh's arrival in Bombay towards the end of the first week of July 1939 heralded the start of a new career, in his own words, 'a metamorphosis, rich and strange for an administrative officer'[3], which ended seventeen years later with his resignation as Union Finance Minister